Tailoring OUM for Your Project

INTRODUCTION

The Oracle® Unified Method (OUM) provides support for the entire Enterprise IT lifecycle, including the successful implementation of every Oracle product. However it is unlikely that any given project will involve the implementation of “every Oracle product”; therefore, it is important to tailor OUM to suit project-specific profiles.

Tailoring refers to the creation of a project-specific work breakdown structure (WBS) coupled with guidance around the “depth” to which OUM activities and tasks should be executed. Within OUM, most of this approach is specific to the task, Develop Baseline Project Workplan (WM.010).

This tailoring approach is applicable for projects of any size led by Oracle Consulting, customers, or partners.

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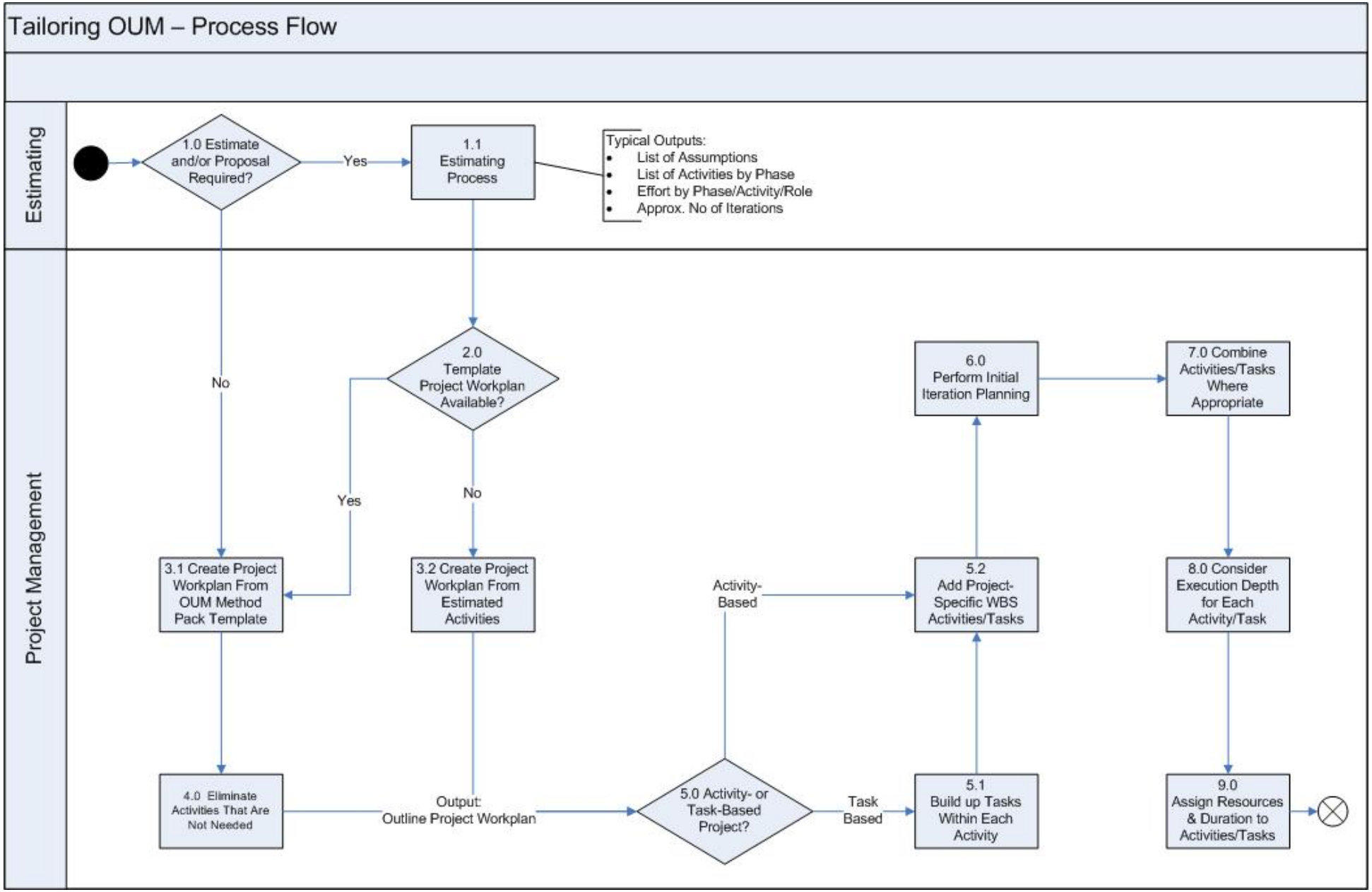
OUM TAILORING PROCESS

The following diagram represents a high-level view of the OUM tailoring process. Each of the numbered tasks is described in more detail within this document.



1.1 Estimating Process

For projects led by Oracle Consulting, the estimating process typically occurs during the sales cycle. For customer or partner-led projects, an alternative pre-planning process may be used. From a project work planning perspective, the key outputs of the estimating or pre-planning process should include:

- List of Assumptions
- List of Activities by Phase
- Effort by Phase / Activity / Role

- Approximate Number of Iterations

2.0 Template Project Workplan Available?

The process of creating a Project Workplan is simplified by using a template as a starting point. An OUM Project Workplan is available with pre-tailoring capability for most Implement views. Other views have example Project Workplans (MS Project) included that can be found in the Key Components section of the view. Consider using one of these as a starting point for creating a project-specific Project Workplan after determining which best matches the project profile.

Alternately, you may have access to a Project Workplan based on another OUM project with characteristics similar to your project profile.

3.1 Create Project Workplan from OUM Method Pack Template

If a suitable Project Workplan template is available, make a copy of the template to use as the basis for your Project Workplan.

3.2 Create Project Workplan from Estimated Activities

When tailoring begins with an estimating or pre-planning process, the starting point for the creation of the Project Workplan is typically a list of activities and associated work effort.

For low-risk, low-complexity, short duration types of projects that do not begin with an estimating or pre-planning process, you should select the OUM activities that apply to your project profile. Refer to supplemental guidance within OUM for a list of recommended tasks and activities applicable to specific project types.

4.0 Eliminate Activities That are Not Needed

If you are using a Project Workplan template as the basis for your Project Workplan, review the list of OUM activities within the template and remove any that are not needed. Remember it is better to “build-up” than to “tailor down”. One way to decide which activities to include in your Project Workplan is to review the supplemental guidance, within OUM, that is applicable to your project profile.

For projects led by Oracle Consulting, you will need to compare the list of activities derived from the estimating process with those in the Project Workplan template. Consider deleting those activities from the Project Workplan which are not included in the estimate. Take note of all activity and task dependencies before deleting any activity.

For customer or partner-led projects, the Project Workplan creation process may begin with an OUM Project Workplan template. In this situation the concept of “build up” rather than “tailor down” needs to be deployed. In practice this means starting with a core set of activities or tasks and only adding additional activities or tasks when it is truly necessary.

5.0 Activity- or Task-Based Project?

Regardless of the starting point for the creation of the Project Workplan, at this step within the process, you should have a list of activities for your project. The next decision point is to determine whether to plan and manage your project at an OUM task or activity level. The most common approach is the task level. Tasks generally last longer than one day and have clearly defined work products. However, for some low-risk, low-complexity, short duration types of projects, it may be feasible to plan and manage the project at the activity level.

To help make this determination, review the key work products guidance available from the Key Components section of the OUM views.

If you elect to plan and manage the project at an OUM activity level, then review each task within an activity and decide which work products the project team will generate at the activity level. This can be accomplished using the Activities and Task list available from the Key Components section of the OUM views.

5.1 Build Up Tasks Within Each Activity

If you elect to plan and manage your project at the task level, then the next step is to add tasks to the required activities. OUM employs a concept of “building up” rather than “tailoring down”. In terms of creating a Project Workplan, this essentially means including the minimum number of tasks required to meet the project objectives and quality criteria.

When determining which tasks to include in the Project Workplan, review the supplemental guidance, within OUM, that is applicable to the project profile. Pay particular attention to the list of recommended and optional tasks. Recommended tasks should be included in your Project Workplan. Inclusion of optional tasks depends on the specifics of your project profile.

If you used a Project Workplan template as a starting point for your Project Workplan, then the “build-up” process essentially involves deleting those tasks which are not required from each activity of your Project Workplan.

If you used the list of activities from the estimating or pre-planning process as a starting point for your Project Workplan, then the “build-up” process involves adding those tasks required to each activity of your Project Workplan.

5.2 Add Project-Specific WBS Activities/Tasks

The output of the estimating or pre-planning process may include additional project-specific WBS activities and tasks. These activities and tasks should be added to the Project Workplan.

6.0 Perform Initial Iteration Planning

The next step is to consider iteration planning. Refer to Planning a Project Using the Oracle Unified Method (OUM) – An Iterative and Incremental Approach.

7.0 Combine Activities / Tasks Where Appropriate

There are certain situations where it may be appropriate to combine tasks or activities. For example, a Project Workplan may include a contracted deliverable which includes the output from two or more tasks, executed by the same project workgroup, in a relatively short amount of time.

Consider this example:

- TE.005 Determine Testing Requirements
- TE.010 Develop Testing Strategy

If the project in question includes a contracted deliverable called “Testing Requirements & Strategy,” then these two tasks could be combined into a single piece of work reflected on the Project Workplan as a single task called, “Define Testing Requirements & Strategy."

Refer to the applicable supplemental guidance and key work products within OUM.

8.0 Consider Execution Depth for Each Activity / Task

A task within OUM is defined as the “lowest unit of work”. Another way to think of a task is that it acts as a “placeholder” for a piece of work. One of the most critical considerations when tailoring OUM for any given project is the “depth” or “rigor” to which tasks should be executed. Before deciding on the “depth” of task execution, the project manager needs to understand the characteristics of the project and whether that project will be executed in an agile or disciplined manor (or somewhere in between).

Consider this example:

OUM task, RD.011 – Develop Future Process Model, is scheduled to occur on Project A which is being conducted in an agile fashion. In this type of environment, the standard Oracle business process flow diagrams are shown to the customer and are manually annotated with marker pens in order to highlight any changes. The marked up diagrams are then scanned and stored on the project server and act as the agreed definition of the future business process.

OUM task, RD.011 – Develop Future Process Model, is scheduled to occur on Project B which is being conducted in a disciplined fashion. In this type of environment, the project team consultants review the standard Oracle business process flow diagrams and then update the diagrams with known customer specific changes. The business process flow diagrams are then used in a customer-facing workshop environment where the future process is agreed. Finally, the completed diagrams are electronically updated to reflect the changes and published for approval.

As you can see from this example, while the same OUM task is being executed, the “depth” to which the task is executed is determined by the level of agility or discipline that is

applied to the project. For additional guidance, refer to the "Flexible and Scalable" section of OUM's Method Overview.

Once the project manager understands the "depth" of execution for each task, then the appropriate amount of work effort can be assigned to that task (or summary task) within the Project Workplan.

9.0 Assign Resources and Durations to Activities / Tasks

The final step is to assign duration to the activities or tasks. Perform this step in conjunction with iteration planning.

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CONCLUSION

The Oracle® Unified Method (OUM) provides support for the entire Enterprise IT lifecycle, including the successful implementation of every Oracle product. It is very unlikely that any given project will involve the implementation of "every Oracle product"; therefore, it is important to tailor OUM to suit project-specific profiles.

- The starting point for a Project Workplan is the list of activities and associated work effort generated from the estimating or pre-planning process.
- Use the OUM Project Workplan templates in conjunction with the list of activities derived from the estimating or pre-planning process.
- Review the Supplemental Guides and Key Work Products.
- Consider combining tasks, where appropriate.
- Consider the "depth" to which tasks should be executed. Remember that the output of a task is not necessarily a physical work product.
- If a task is not needed, remove it from the Project Workplan.
- Tasks and work products should be scaled to suite project specific need.

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